

Heat Inequality in Hong Kong: Who Gets to Stay Cool?

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At 2 a.m. in Sham Shui Po, an old cleaner tries to sleep in a subdivided room. His fan is turning, but the air still feels like hot soup. Outside, Hong Kong looks bright and rich. Behind glass walls, luxury flats and malls keep air-conditioners running. Buildings use about 90% of HK's electricity, and this power creates over 50% of the city's carbon emissions (GovHK, n.d.). In 2024, Hong Kong had 50 Hot Nights, so this night is not rare now (Hong Kong Observatory [HKO], 2025a). The cleaner wants to switch on the air-con, but he thinks about the bill first.

Hong Kong is heating up, but the heat is not equal. HKO shows that the annual mean temperature rose by 0.14°C per decade from 1885 to 2025. The speed became faster from 1996 to 2025, reaching 0.35°C per decade. In 2024, Hong Kong recorded its warmest year, with 24.8°C annual mean temperature and 52 hot nights. Under a very high emissions pathway, Hong Kong may face 152 extreme hot weather every year by 2081 to 2100 (Hong Kong Observatory, 2025, 2026). These numbers show that heat is already inside daily life. For rich people, heat just means a higher bill. But for those poor families, heat can mean bad sleep or even losing dignity.

My solution is a “Cool Home, Cool Street” programme. The idea is simple. Hong Kong should treat cooling as basic protection, but not a luxury. The programme should start in Sham Shui Po, Kwun Tong, and old new-town areas. Dense buildings, old flats, and many low-income people are gathered in those places.

The programme requires a public heat-risk map. The map should combine HKO temperature data, urban heat island data, and census data on subdivided units. In 2021, Hong Kong had about 108,200 subdivided units, and 215,700 people lived in them. Their median floor area was only 11.0 square metres (Census and Statistics Department, 2023). This data can accurately tell the government where help should go first. It should not only follow rich districts or property value.

The project also needs a “cooling repair kit” for poor homes. The kit can include reflective window film, better exhaust fans, and government subsidy for efficient air-conditioners. The subsidy should go to tenants. Landlords should promise that they will not increase rent after improvement. NGOs can check whether the action has been actually implemented.

The street also needs cooling. Many people leave hot rooms and go outside, but the street is also burning. The city should add shade at bus stops, wet markets, playgrounds, and public housing entrances. Trees are useful, but trees are farly not enough. Hong Kong also needs covered walkways, drinking water points, and cooling rooms opened at night during Hot Night warnings.

This plan works because it makes the housing and the community better with the support of data. Research in Hong Kong found that during extreme heat, areas with strong urban heat island effects had almost twice the mortality risk compared with more moderate areas. Elderly people aged 75 or above were especially vulnerable (Ho et al., 2023). In HK, heatstroke leads to more than 200 hospital admissions each year, with about 2 to 5 deaths annually, mostly between May and September (Centre for Health Protection, 2025). Heat is not just uncomfortable; it can become a serious health danger.

The people who benefit most are subdivided-flat families, elderly residents, outdoor workers, cleaners, security guards, or students. A cooler home can help people sleep better, work better, and study more comfortably. In addition, businesses also benefit due to the fewer sick leaves. The climate could be improved, if subsidies support only energy-efficient appliances and better building design. This also fits Hong Kong's Climate Action Plan 2050, which promotes energy saving and green buildings (GovHK, n.d.).

People can take action today. You can download the HKO app and check Hot Night warnings. You can call an elderly neighbor during very hot nights. You can set your air conditioner to 25.5°C when possible. Students can record their room temperature for one week and share the results with classmates, NGOs, or district councilors. The question we should keep asking is simple: “Who cannot afford to cool down?”

Hong Kong often calls itself an efficient city. But in the age of climate change, efficiency is not enough. A good city should not only move quickly; it should also allow people to breathe. If heat is unequal, then cooling must become a matter of justice.

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